Among the Bumblebees

By Sylvia Plath

(Pgs 320-326) In the beginning there was Alice Denway's father, tossing her up in the air until the breath caught in her throat, and catching her and holding her in a huge bear hug. With her ear against his chest, young Alice could hear the thunder of his heart and the pulse of blood in his veins, like the sound of wild horses galloping.

Alice Denway's father had been a giant of a man. In the blue blaze of his eyes was concentrated the color of the whole overhead dome of sky, and when he laughed, it sounded as if all the waves of the ocean were breaking and roaring up the beach together. Alice worshiped her father because he was so powerful, and everybody did what he commanded because he knew best.

INTRODUCTION

The bond between a father and his daughter can be one of the most important relationships in a young girl's life.

Alice Denway moves through a world that hums with her father's power. Like the bumblebees he so

4NG Fanatics

effortlessly captures and releases, Alice is drawn to him . . . awed by his strength, unknowingly influenced by its grasp.

Alice depends on her father's strength to show her how to navigate the world. But when the illusion of her father's invincibility starts to falter, when the steady buzz of control gives way to silence, Alice is left alone and uncertain . . .

Among the Bumblebees by Sylvia Plath

There had been that spring evening . . . "Who's my girl?" he asked her fondly, tweaking at a pigtail.

"Alice is!" she cried out, bouncing in her chair. "Can I watch you correct tonight?"

*"**May**,"* said her father. "Yes, you may, if you are very quiet." He wiped his lips on his napkin, folded it, and tossed it on the table, pushing back his chair.

Alice followed her father into the den and went to sit in one of the big, slippery leather chairs near his desk. She liked to watch him correcting the papers he brought home in his briefcase, fixing the mistakes that people had made. He would go reading along, and then all at once stop, pick up his colored pencil and make little red gashes here and there where the words were wrong.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

"Do you know," her father had said once, looking up suddenly from his work, "what will happen tomorrow when I hand these papers back in class? There will be," her father intoned in mock severity, with a black frown, "a weeping and wailing and a gnashing of teeth."

Alice had thought, then, of the great hall at the college where her father stood, high upon a platform. Hundreds of people came to listen to her father talk and tell them wonderful strange things about how the world was made.

She had pictured him standing up there, handing down papers to the people, calling them by name, each one. Like a king, high on a throne, he would call out the names in his thundering voice, and the people would come, trembling and frightened, to take their papers. And then, rising mournfully, there would be the sound of weeping, of wailing, and gnashing of teeth. Alice hoped that she would be there some day when the people were gnashing their teeth; she was sure that it would make a terrible and awe-inspiring noise.

In the summertime, her father did not go to town at all. He would take her to the beach. First Father would go for

4N6 Fanatics

a swim himself, leaving her on the shore, with the small waves collapsing at her feet and the wet sand sliding up cool between her toes. Alice would stand ankle-deep, watching him admiringly from the edge of the breakers, shielding her eyes against the blinding glare of summer sun that struck silent and brilliant on the surface of the water.

After a while she would call to him, and he would turn and begin swimming shoreward, carving a line of foam behind him with his legs and cleaving the water ahead with the powerful propellers of his arms. He would come to her and lift her onto his back, where she clung, her arms locked about his neck, and go swimming out again. In an ecstasy of terror, she would hold on to him, her soft cheek prickling where she laid her face against the back of his neck, her legs and slender body trailing out behind her, floating, moving effortlessly along in her father's energetic wake.

And gradually, there on her father's back, Alice's fear would leave her, and the water, black and deep beneath her, would seem calm and friendly, obeying the skillful

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

mastery of her father's rhythmic stroke and supporting both of them upon the level waves.

Alice's father feared nothing. Power was good because it was power, and when the summer storms came, with the crackling blue sheet lightning and the ear-splitting thunderclaps, Alice's father would roar with laughter. Alice learned to sing the thunder song with her father: "Thor is angry. Thor is angry. Boom, boom, boom! Boom, boom, boom! We don't care. We don't care. Boom, boom, boom!" And above the resonant resounding baritone of her father's voice, the thunder rumbled harmless as a tame lion.

Sitting on her father's lap in the den, watching the waves at the end of the street whipped to a ragged froth of foam, Alice learned to laugh at the destructive grandeur of the elements. The swollen purple and black clouds broke open with blinding flashes of light, and the thunderclaps made the house shudder to the root of its foundations. But with her father's strong arms around her and the steady reassuring beat of his heart in her ears, Alice believed that he was somehow connected with the

4N6 Fanatics

miracle of fury beyond the windows, and that through him, she could face the doomsday of the world in perfect safety.

When it was the right time of year, her father took her into the garden and showed her how he could catch bumblebees. That was something no one else's father could do. Her father caught a special kind of bumblebee that he recognized by its shape and held it in his closed fist, putting his hand to her ear. Alice liked to hear the angry, stifled buzzing of the bee, captured in the dark trap of her father's hand, but not stinging, not daring to sting. Then, with a laugh, her father would spread his fingers wide, and the bee would fly out, free, up into the air and away.

One summer, Alice's father did not take her out to catch bees. He lay inside the house on the couch and Mother brought him trays with orange juice in tall glasses. He drank a lot of water, for he was very thirsty all the time.

It went on like that for a long while. At night, after Alice was in bed, she could hear Mother speaking to Father in the next room, and her voice would go along very soft

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

and low for a while, until Father would get cross and raise his voice like thunder.

One day, after a night like this, the doctor came to see Father, and after he had left, Father began to stay in bed -- doctor's orders. There was whispering, now, instead of talking. The doctor wanted the blinds in Father's room kept down because the sunlight was too bright and hurt [his] eyes.

The doctor, bringing his black bag and smiling a foolish bright smile, pulled playfully at Alice's pigtail, but she switched it away from him with a pout and a toss of her head. Father winked at her, but Mother shook her head.

"Be nice, Alice," she begged. "The doctor's here to help Father."

That was not true. Father did not need any help. The doctor was making him stay in bed; he shut out the sun and that was making Father unhappy. Father could tell the plump silly doctor to go out of the house, if he wanted to. Father could slam the door after him and order him never to come back again. But instead, Father let the doctor take a big silver needle out of the black bag and

4NG Fanatics

swab a sterile place on Father's arm and stab the needle in.

Father did not wince at all. He let the needle go in and looked at her with his strong blue eyes, silently telling her that really he did not care; he was only humoring Mother and the absurd fat little doctor. Alice felt her eyes fill up with tears of pride. But she blinked back the tears and did not cry. Father did not like anyone to cry.

The next day Alice went to visit her father again. She tiptoed into the room, which smelled sweet and strange with alcohol. Father was asleep, lying motionless on the bed except for the rhythmic rising and falling of the blankets over his chest and the sound of his breathing. In the muted light, his face was the sallow color of candle wax, and the flesh was lean and taut about his mouth.

Alice stood looking down at her father's gaunt face, clenching and unclenching her thin hands by her side and listening to the slow thread of his breathing. Then she leaned over the bed and put her head down on the bedclothes above his chest. From somewhere, very faint and far off, she could hear the weak pulsing of his heart,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

like the fading throb of a distant drum.

"Father," she said in a small pleading voice. "Father." But he did not hear . . . Lost and betrayed, she slowly turned away and left the room.

That was the last time that Alice Denway saw her father. She did not know then that in all the rest of her life there would be no one to walk with her, like him, proud and arrogant among the bumblebees.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sylvia Plath
Book: Johnny Panic and the Bible of Dreams, Pgs 320-326
ISBN: 978-0061549472
Publisher: Harper Perennial Modern Classics
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2008

AWARD HISTORY

2024 National Qualifier - MS

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY